

Chapter 133 - Schemes

After the lamp was extinguished, only tree shadows remained swaying in the room. Aunt Luo's snoring from next door came clearly through the thin wall. Ning Fuyi suddenly smiled and turned sideways, embracing Chu Qingqiu's waist from behind.

Her waist was slender enough to encircle with one arm, with her remaining hand resting on the bed, clenched into a fist.

Ning Fuyi's action was initially tentative, but after a while, just as she was about to withdraw her arm, Chu Qingqiu actually leaned back against her. Ning Fuyi's heart immediately pressed against her back, beating non-stop.

She buried her face in her hair, breathing in the faint fragrance.

"Why aren't you sleeping?" Chu Qingqiu spoke with her eyes closed, her voice light and distant.

"Thinking about Penglai¹," Ning Fuyi said honestly, tightening her embrace. "What Penglai wants to achieve by refining the Infinite Ghost Fire."

"Chu Qingqiu, can you tell me more about that ancient evil spirit?" Ning Fuyi asked.

Chu Qingqiu opened her eyes, her peach blossom eyes clear and bright.

"You already know about it, what else do you want to hear?" she asked.

"I know about the ancient evil spirit, but you haven't told me about that demon who's determined to deal with me. What's his relationship with the evil spirit?"

Bird calls came from outside the window, and her clear voice continued: "Regarding your rebirth, I've always felt something is deeply suspicious. In your previous life when you became a demon, that demon clan member never appeared, and Penglai rarely showed itself. Though the curse may have changed fate, it wouldn't have affected things so completely."

"I don't understand much about that demon either, only that his demonic power was so strong it was terrifying. Before he died, he mentioned someone, saying that after killing me and then you, he could report back to that person."

"But in the thirty years after my death, you never faced threats from other demons, did you?" Chu Qingqiu suddenly asked.

Ning Fuyi nodded.

She had even invaded the demon territory and established herself as a leader. Those little demons and spirits had the longest tongues - if there had been more powerful demons appearing, she wouldn't have been unaware.

"That's what I find most suspicious," Chu Qingqiu said. "Now, only Penglai is targeting you for your life."

"At that time, I was already near death, and the demon was pressing you too urgently for your life. I could only perish together with him, showing you Ning Changfeng's memories, hoping that afterward you could pull yourself together to face the countless difficulties ahead."

"But these difficulties turned out to be Penglai, which was truly beyond my expectations."

Ning Fuyi listened, her eyes filled with myriad thoughts, finally nodding slowly.

"Sleep, dawn is almost here," she said softly.

This night was also one of changing circumstances - bright moon and sparse stars in the first half, cloudy with drizzling rain in the second half.

The Penglai great hall was similarly filled with dark clouds. Two rows of candles illuminated the entire hall brilliantly, with golden threads gleaming on the luxurious curtains, embroidering the mountains and rivers of the Six Realms² in flowing colors.

Several people knelt in the center of the hall, all bowing their heads submissively, not daring to speak.

"Tell this lord again, what was destroyed?" The man's deep, resonant voice came from behind the curtains, making the kneeling people nearly wet themselves with fear.

"Re-replying to Your Majesty..." a black-clothed man trembled as he spoke, "it was that demon surnamed Ning, who joined with several immortal sect members to break into Xuanyuan Kingdom³ and destroyed the Infinite Ghost Fire..."

No sound came from behind the curtains for a long while. The hall was so quiet that even the whooshing sound of burning candles could be heard clearly.

"Where are the guards? Where is Black Scales?" The man's voice came again, emotion undetectable.

"The guards were killed by Black Scales, and Black Scales..." the man pressed close to the ground, "whereabouts unknown."

As soon as he finished speaking, a loud crash came from behind the hall, wind swept overhead, and the hall doors actually flew out with a thunderous crash, shattering in the night outside.

The sound made the entire hall shake three times. The kneeling people dared not even breathe, trembling into a huddle.

"The Infinite Ghost Fire, extinguished?" A low laugh came from behind the curtains, and a pale, slender hand emerged to lift the curtain, revealing a face beneath a row of jade-white pendants.

That face was upright in appearance, but so pale it seemed excessive, as if it hadn't seen daylight for thousands of years, faintly revealing a sickly pallor. Under his dark sword-like brows, his eyes were bottomlessly deep, vaguely exposing an aura completely at odds with his appearance.

The hem of his robe embroidered with golden pythons slid down the steps, dragging with his movements.

"Yes," the man who had spoken earlier said tremblingly again. A flash of light appeared behind his ear, and he was immediately lifted by the throat by that light, struggling frantically with all four limbs.

The light turned out to be several silk threads. The threads were sharp by nature, and his neck soon began bleeding. The others kneeling beside him quickly spoke up: "Your Majesty, Your Majesty, though the Infinite Ghost Fire is extinguished, the fire seed remains. Please show mercy, Your Majesty!"

The several people cried out heart-rendingly before Tianrui Emperor⁴ finally released his grip. The man tumbled down gasping, clutching his neck and coughing up several mouthfuls of bloody phlegm.

"Where is the fire seed?" the man said softly.

A woman in blue robes quickly took out a stone box from her bosom, carefully placing it before her, then turned back to help the man, not daring to cry aloud.

Tianrui Emperor slowly walked forward, lifting the box lid like a precious treasure. When the deep blue flame as thick as a little finger came into view, he suddenly let out a long breath, laughed, and cradled the box in his palms.

Then his expression immediately turned cold: "Wenyao Jun⁵."

Wenyao Jun's figure appeared behind the several people, glancing down at the man with his neck covered in blood without looking further: "Your Majesty."

"These people failed in their guard duty. Cast them into Yichan Sea⁶," he said, stroking the fire seed regardless of its heat. "You quickly lead troops to capture Black Scales. Once caught, kill without question."

The words "kill without question" were spoken lightly, but still made people's blood run cold upon hearing them. Wenyao Jun's brow furrowed slightly as he cupped his hands: "Yes, Your Majesty."

"Also, bring Cloud Guest⁷."

After Wenyao Jun led the others away, Tianrui Emperor stared at the night for a long time, then suddenly raised his hand to restore the hall doors. Cloud Guest's slender figure appeared in the center of the flickering candlelight.

Water-blue robes draped his body, pale lashes lowered, completely covering those eyes bright as a starry river.

His hair was bound with a jade hairpin, with remaining strands flowing in the wind.

He could not speak, only standing quietly.

"Cloud Guest, are you truly loyal to this lord?" the man said in a low voice.

Cloud Guest nodded.

"That's good." Tianrui Emperor suddenly smiled. He slowly approached Cloud Guest, raising his hand as several silk threads wound around Cloud Guest's wrists. Panic immediately filled Cloud Guest's eyes, yet after standing frozen for a moment, he did not dodge.

Then the silk threads pulled him forward. Cloud Guest staggered as he moved, the threads cutting his skin and revealing fresh blood that dripped into the flame.

The Infinite Ghost Fire, smelling the merman⁸ blood, found it incredibly sweet and instantly grew larger, greedily devouring the blood drops, even climbing up along the blood's trajectory as if to envelop Cloud Guest's arm.

Cloud Guest immediately panicked. He hurriedly tried to retreat, but the man gripped his throat with one hand, firmly controlling him above the flames.

His voice was full of false compassion: "Didn't you just say you would always be loyal to this lord? Be at ease - as long as someone is loyal, this lord will not harm their life."

Seeing his blood about to run dry, Cloud Guest fearfully made hand gestures, begging the man to release him. However, the man acted as if he saw nothing, only staring hopefully at the blue color of the gradually dimming Infinite Ghost Fire.

More and more blood flowed. Cloud Guest's vision was already darkening, those beautiful eyes losing their brilliance as he tilted his head back and went limp.

Fortunately, by this time there was enough fresh blood. Tianrui Emperor released his grip, and Cloud Guest crashed heavily to the ground, curling up his body, unconscious.

Tianrui Emperor bent down and fed Cloud Guest a pill.

The precious merman blood had already caused the Infinite Ghost Fire to display an ice-blue color, but it was still far from being refined into true ghost fire. Tianrui Emperor stared at the flame for a long while, finally slowly rolling up his left sleeve.

There was no madness in his eyes, only complete calm.

"I use my essence blood as guide, my sacred body as sacrifice, praying for the Infinite to reignite, for chaos to return," he recited in unclear words.

Then his right hand formed a sharp blade. Raising his hand above the ghost fire without the slightest hesitation, he brought the knife down. Thus, accompanied by the sound of spurting blood, his pale arm immediately separated from his body, spinning as it fell into the ghost fire.

The moment flesh contacted the ghost fire, the entire hall erupted in brilliant white light. The candlelight immediately paled in comparison. The man knelt in agony, convulsing as blood gushed from his severed arm.

His snow-white face twisted in pain, yet he clutched his arm and began to laugh eerily.

Ning Fuyi woke to find the weather had cleared. Last night's light rain had seeped into the dry earth, and the entire small courtyard was filled with the simple scent of soil.

They declined Aunt Luo's kind invitation to join them for breakfast, deciding to set out early to avoid Penglai's people tracking them here and implicating the common people.

Before leaving, Ning Fuyi secretly slipped Yuange a jade bead, telling her to keep it safe. If she ever encountered difficulties in the future, she should place the bead on the ground, face it, and kowtow three times toward the southeast.

Yuange listened carefully, cautiously putting away the bead. She wrapped her short arms around Ning Fuyi's neck and planted a sweet, soft kiss on her cheek.

After leaving the small town, Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu released White Lin⁹ and headed south.

Chu Qingqiu said the others had all returned to Star Point Town, so Ning Fuyi decided to meet up with everyone first to properly explain what had happened, so they could face Penglai together.

The two flew for a day and night. When they reached Star Point Town, it was nearly noon. White Lin insisted on chasing a red-bottomed bird. Chu Qingqiu couldn't control it, so Ning Fuyi had to land first, planning to enter Star Point Town to wait for her.

But as soon as she stepped onto the green grass, a strange fragrance wafted to her nose. At the same time, a long whip came flying at her face. Ning Fuyi tilted her head back to dodge the whip, casually reaching out to wrap the whip around twice, and with a forceful pull, snatched it from the woman's hands.

"Sect Leader Hua!" Li Hanxi¹⁰ immediately shouted. At the same time, fierce winds rolled behind Ning Fuyi, and a wooden puppet several times her size thundered to the ground, its giant axe chopping toward her.

Ning Fuyi was too lazy to draw out her Emei Thorns¹¹, simply grabbing the long whip and holding it horizontally in front of her. The whip was immediately cut in two by the axe.

"My whip!" Li Hanxi screamed, fury blazing as she formed claws with her hands, trying to grab at Ning Fuyi's vital points. "You demon! Now that the evidence is clear, why don't you surrender? Today I will definitely capture you and bind you for the six sects to see!"

Though Li Hanxi's cultivation was high, she practiced seduction arts¹² after all. Ning Fuyi wasn't afraid of her, but just as she was about to counterattack, she saw a white light in the sky.

So her phoenix eyes shimmered, and she suddenly withdrew her hand, spinning to dodge the fatal strike, using her shoulder and back to meet Li Hanxi's claws, pretending to be injured by her.

Author's Note: Yiyi: So you like my wife, do you?

Footnotes:

1. **蓬莱 (Penglai)** - A mystical realm in Chinese mythology, often depicted as a paradise inhabited by immortals.
2. **六界 (Six Realms)** - The six realms of existence in Chinese Buddhist and Daoist cosmology.
3. **轩辕国 (Xuanyuan Kingdom)** - Named after the Yellow Emperor (Xuanyuan), a legendary Chinese ruler.
4. **天瑞帝君 (Tianrui Emperor)** - The antagonist ruler of Penglai.
5. **文曜君 (Wenyao Jun)** - A title meaning "Lord of Literary Brilliance," one of Tianrui Emperor's subordinates.
6. **一阐海 (Yichan Sea)** - A place of punishment or exile.
7. **云客 (Cloud Guest)** - A character name meaning "visitor among clouds."
8. **鲛人 (Merman)** - Mythical sea creatures in Chinese folklore, similar to mermaids but with magical properties.
9. **白麟 (White Lin)** - A white qilin (Chinese unicorn), a mythical creature.
10. **李菡萏 (Li Hanxi)** - A character name; 菡萏 refers to lotus buds.
11. **峨眉刺 (Emei Thorns)** - Ning Fuyi's signature weapon.
12. **合欢术 (Seduction Arts)** - A type of cultivation practice involving charm and seduction techniques.